

Supporting Emeritus Scientists in Research

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Emeritus professors make substantial contributions to science through research, refereeing, mentoring and advising, often at negligible cost. Yet support varies widely internationally, from active emeritus programmes at ETH Zürich, Leiden and in the UK to largely honorary status with minimal infrastructure in France, Italy and Spain.

The evidence does not support assumptions of inevitable decline at retirement age. Nearly 40 percent of U.S.-trained doctoral scientists aged 71 to 75 remain actively employed. While individual productivity varies, the question is whether systems enable those wishing to contribute to do so.

Concerns about competition with early-career scientists reflect a zero-sum view of research funding. Emeriti typically require different support, bringing collaborative funding, contributing to ongoing projects and taking on reviewing and administrative work that would otherwise burden mid-career colleagues.

We propose four practical steps. First, institutions should provide basic infrastructure: affiliation, email, library access and, where feasible, workspace. Second, international mobility should be encouraged through retired scientist exchange programmes. Third, funding bodies should adopt age-blind grant eligibility assessed on merit alone. Fourth, modest emeritus-specific funding should support collaborative projects pairing senior expertise with junior innovation.

The financial case is straightforward. Supporting 1,000 emeritus professors with 10,000 euros each would cost 10 million euros annually, negligible compared to Horizon Europe's 93.5 billion euro budget. More importantly, science is conducted by people. The knowledge, judgment and connections accumulated over long careers do not expire when employment ends. A research system that discards these resources due to age is not being efficient, but wasteful.

Word count: 234